



“ Singh’s Summersaults ”

THEN March 2006

“I had gone to Sonia’s house, there I was insulted and called a beggar and a dog and thrown out.”

NOW

“1999 was a mistake. You say I have changed, remember what Pawar said about Sonia earlier.”

THEN January 2006

“I welcome Sonia’s *goondas*. If there is a scratch on me, then Sonia is to be blamed.”

NOW

“I cannot say Sonia Gandhi is my friend. She is a leader of stature. So how can she be my friend?”

THEN December 2007

“Manmohan Singh is an honourable person but the deal he is pursuing is not an honourable one.”

NOW

“If the prime minister had briefed us earlier on the deal, we could have supported it much before.”

addition, some of Amar Singh’s friends claim to have been “harassed” by the Income Tax Department.

Also Mulayam is not yet ready for an election. He needs time for anti-incumbency to hit Mayawati. So, it is not just a political platitude when Amar Singh says: “We are not in this for power. The Congress won’t have any problems with us.” This has, however, not stopped the flamboyant Thakur from flexing his rediscovered political muscle for effect. Unlike the earthy Mulayam, he knows power alone is not important. It is also

the appearance of power, which explains his attack on two of UPA’s Cabinet ministers. While Finance Minister P. Chidambaram was blamed for inflation, Petroleum Minister Murli Deora (and industrialist friend Anil Ambani’s *bête noire*) was attacked for “anti-people” policies. “He should come clean whether he is a corporate honcho or a minister,” thundered Amar Singh, unmindful of the irony. And then added that both were his friends—this was not personal, it was business. The Congress, as of now, is neither shaken nor stirred. It says it will not drop the ministers and hopes that a sweetheart deal in Uttar Pradesh and the shared fear of an early election will curtail the duo. Moreover, after the vote of confidence, the Congress knows the duo will lose some of its bargaining power. Even if SP withdraws support, there cannot be another floor test for six months.

Milking his long-lost prominence for all its worth though, Amar Singh also let it slip that his party was courted by the BJP—specifically Jaswant Singh who came with an offer to prop up Mulayam as prime minister last year and again last week. He has already dashed off two letters to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh this week criticising certain policy decisions and suggesting remedies. Signing off “Yours Affectionately” he ended one letter with a handwritten note, “I would like to meet you regarding this before any decision is taken.” These letters were promptly released to the media so that no one missed the post-script—Singh is back. And so is the excitement in the Capital’s politics as he now raves about Sonia’s leadership skills and rants against the media that reminds him of his earlier tirades. It is not just talk. The duo has also been doing its spade work, getting former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam’s approval for the deal to counter the charge that Indian Muslims are opposed to a pact with the US.

Mulayam’s joined-at-the-hip relationship with Amar Singh has cost him many SP loyalists in the past, with Beni Prasad Verma, Raj Babbar and Janeshwar Mishra objecting to his friendship with the five-star Thakur. But Mulayam has always held fast. As the events last week showed, it’s been Mulayam’s best career move, taking him from mofussil to mainstream. ■